Deacon Shepherding System

Goal: No one drifts invisibly. "Our goal isn't to increase attendance. Our goal is to prevent isolation."

The Deacon's Quiet Mission

You are:

- Watching for isolation.
- Guarding against discouragement.
- Preserving unity.
- Encouraging perseverance.

This is kingdom work.

It is small.
It is unseen.
It is powerful.

A Short Theology of Why Deacons Do This

Deaconal Care Is Not Attendance Management

It flows from:

1. The Nature of the Body (1 Cor. 12)

If one member is missing, the body feels it.

2. The Pattern of the Shepherd (Luke 15)

The shepherd goes after the one.

3. The Danger of Drift (Heb. 3:12–13)

“Exhort one another daily… that none may be hardened.”

Drift is rarely loud. It is gradual.

4. The Ministry of Presence (Acts 6)

Deacons ensure no one is neglected.

Neglect is rarely intentional — it is usually administrative.

Deacons prevent accidental neglect.

A Simple Line You Can Use With Council

That keeps it pastoral, not programmatic.

Deacon Care Covenant

As deacons, we commit to:

1. Pray regularly for the members entrusted to us.
2. Notice absence without suspicion.
3. Reach out without accusation.
4. Guard against isolation.
5. Coordinate with elders when deeper care is needed.
6. Keep confidences wisely.
7. Reflect Christ's gentleness in all interactions.

We do this not to monitor attendance, but to preserve unity, encourage perseverance, and embody the love of Christ.

A Quiet Framework Underneath It All

Genesis 3 – “Where are you?”
Luke 15 – The shepherd goes.
Acts 6 – No one neglected.
Hebrews 3 – Exhort daily.

Deacons stand at the intersection of care and order.

You prevent invisible fading.

A Strategic Insight

Churches don't usually lose people through heresy.

They lose them through:

- Embarrassment
- Fatigue
- Conflict avoidance
- Quiet discouragement

Your ministry interrupts that silence.

Deacon Care Manual

Our Calling

To guard against neglect and isolation within Christ's body.

Our Goals

- Notice.
- Reach.
- Pray.
- Support.
- Coordinate.

We Do NOT

- Police attendance.
- Argue people back.
- Replace the elders.
- Gossip about concerns.

We DO

- Reach out gently after absence.
- Pray with members.
- Identify practical needs.
- Inform elders when patterns emerge.
- Keep short notes for accountability.

Red Flags

- Avoiding contact.
- Expressing cynicism toward church.
- Ongoing relational conflict.
- Public moral drift.

Response Ladder

1. Gentle contact.
2. Personal visit.
3. Elder involvement.
4. Formal discipline only if necessary.

Our Tone

Warm.
Direct.
Prayerful.
Unhurried.

A Word for The Deacon:

This kind of structure protects you from two errors:

1. Being overly passive.
2. Becoming overly aggressive.

Deacons walk the middle ground:

Firm love.

You preach about:
“Take up your cross.”

Sometimes that cross looks like:
Making a call you don’t feel like making.

Deacon's Call Script Principles

As a deacon, your tone matters more than your wording.

You're not doing a **location check**.
You're doing something closer to what God did in Genesis 3 — not "Where are you physically?" but "Where are you spiritually?"

The goal isn't attendance-policing.
It's shepherding presence.

Below are several options you can use — warm, simple, direct.

A Guiding Principle for All Contacts:

You are not enforcing attendance.

You are guarding against isolation.

Genesis 3 — *“Where are you?”*
Not to shame.
To restore.

One More Thought

Short is strong.

If a call goes 3–5 minutes and ends in prayer, that’s ideal.

You’re planting seeds of belonging.

> Salt preserves.
> Light illuminates.
> Phone calls prevent quiet drift.

1️⃣ Simple Deacon Tracking System (So No One Slips Quietly)

Keep this simple. Over-complex systems die.

📋 The 4-Column Care Grid

You can keep this in a shared Google Sheet or simple printed binder.

Name	Last Seen	Contact Made	Notes / Next Step

Status Categories (Color Code if Digital)

- 🟢 Active – seen within 2 weeks
- 🟡 Missed 2–3 weeks – gentle check-in
- 🟠 Missed 1–2 months – call + follow-up
- 🔴 2+ months – elder awareness + personal visit

Rhythm

- Review list once per month.
- Divide names among deacons.
- Pray through the list before calling.
- Record brief notes (not essays).

Important Rule

You are not building a surveillance system.
You are building a shepherding system.

The goal: **no one drifts invisibly.**

Part 2 - Scripts

📞 Simple, Warm Call Script

Opening

“Hi ___, this is Bert. I just wanted to check in and see how you’re doing. We missed you on Sunday.”

(Pause. Let them respond.)

If they share a reason:

“I’m glad you told me. I just wanted you to know you were noticed — and missed. Is there anything going on that we can pray about or help with?”

If they say ‘just busy’ or ‘nothing much’:

“I understand. I just didn’t want too much time to pass without reaching out. You matter to us. And we’re here.”

Closing

“Can I pray for you before I hang up?”
(Short, sincere prayer — 30 seconds.)

📞 Slightly More Pastoral Version

“Hey ___, this is Bert. I’m calling to check in on you. We missed seeing you Sunday, and I just wanted to make sure you’re doing alright.”

That line lowers defenses immediately.

Then:

“Sometimes when people miss, it’s just life. Sometimes it’s heavier things. Either way, we care.”

📞 Voice Mail Options (Short & Gentle)

“Hi ___, this is Bert from church. Just wanted you to know we missed you Sunday and I wanted to check in. Letting you know we care. Give me a call when you get a chance. We’re praying for you.”

That’s it. Don’t overdo it.

📞 Even Shorter Voice Mail (If You Want Very Simple)

“Hey ___, it’s Bert. Just reaching out because we missed you this week. Hope you’re doing well. Call anytime.”

Tone Principles (More Important Than Script)

As a deacon, your call communicates five things:

1. You were noticed.
2. You are not forgotten.
3. You are part of us.
4. We care about your soul, not just your seat.
5. You don't have to disappear quietly.

Keep it:

- Warm
- Brief
- Non-accusatory
- Prayerful
- Relational

What NOT to Say

- “We noticed you haven’t been in a few weeks.”
- “Everything okay?”
- “You know Hebrews says not to forsake assembling…”

That moves from shepherd to auditor.

A Slightly Deeper Version (If You Know Them Well)

"I just didn't want too much time to pass without hearing your voice. The Christian life is hard, and sometimes isolation creeps in. I just wanted you to know we're here."

That one is strong — use wisely.

Optional Text Message Version

"Hi ___ — we missed you Sunday. Just checking in. Hope you're doing well. Let me know if there's anything we can pray about."

The Big Picture

You are practicing:

- Micah 6:8 — kindness.
- Gal. 6:2 — bearing burdens.
- Luke 15 — going after the one.

You're helping prevent quiet drift.

Discipleship doesn't only happen in the pulpit.
It happens in the phone call.

1️⃣ Someone You Suspect Is Spiritually Cooling

This one requires the most gentleness. You're not confronting. You're inviting.

📞 Phone Call Script

"Hi ___, it's Bert. I've been meaning to call you. You've been on my mind."

(Pause.)

"I just wanted to check in — not about attendance — but about you. How are you doing with the Lord these days?"

That question opens the heart without accusation.

If they deflect:

“I ask because sometimes when we get busy or discouraged, it’s easy to drift quietly. And I didn’t want that to happen without someone reaching out.”

Close with:

“We don’t walk this road alone. I’m here for you.”

This is more shepherd than administrator.

2️⃣ Someone Who Hasn't Attended in Months

This one needs warmth and zero edge.

📞 Phone Call Script

"Hi ___, this is Bert from church. I know it's been a while since we've seen you, but I just wanted you to know you haven't been forgotten."

Pause.

"Life moves fast. Sometimes seasons change. I just wanted to check in and see how you're doing."

If appropriate:

"If there's anything that's made it hard to come back, I'd be glad to listen."

Key phrase: *“You haven’t been forgotten.”*

That’s powerful.

📞 Voice Mail Version

“Hi ___, this is Bert. Just wanted to reach out and let you know you’re remembered and prayed for. No pressure — just care. Call anytime.”

3️⃣ A Young Family

Young families are usually exhausted, not drifting.

📞 Phone Call Script

“Hey ___, it’s Bert. I just wanted to say we’ve missed seeing you guys — and I know life with little ones can be a full-contact sport.”

That line makes them smile.

“Just checking in to see how you’re doing. Anything the church can do to support you?”

You might add:

“Even if Sundays are chaotic right now, we’re still your church family.”

That removes guilt.

📱 Text Version (Often Better for Young Parents)

“Hey ___ — just checking in. We know Sundays with kids can be wild. We miss you guys and are praying for you.”

Keep it light.

🛗 A Shut-In

This is pastoral care more than attendance care.

📞 Phone Call Script

“Hi ___, this is Bert. I just wanted to hear your voice today.”

Pause.

“We miss having you with us, but you’re still very much part of this body.”

You might ask:

“Is there a Scripture that’s been encouraging you lately?”

Or:

“Would it encourage you if someone brought communion or visited?”

Close with prayer.

📞 Voice Mail Version

“Hi ___, just calling to remind you that you’re not forgotten. We’re grateful for you.”

2️⃣ Follow-Up Text Templates (After a Call)

These reinforce care without hovering.

After a Good Conversation

"Thanks for talking today. Grateful for you. Praying for ___ this week."

After Leaving a Voice Mail

"Just left you a voicemail — no rush. Just wanted to check in."

After Someone Shares a Struggle

"Still praying for you about ___ today. The Lord sees."

If They Say They'll Return Soon

"Looking forward to seeing you when you're able. We'll save you a seat."

Short. Personal. Warm.

1️⃣ Six-Month Re-Engagement Plan (For Someone Long Absent)

This is not a pressure plan.
It is a presence plan.

Month 1 – Warm Contact

- Personal phone call.
- Follow-up text.
- Note in tracking grid.
- Pray by name in deacon meeting.

Tone: "You're remembered."

Month 2 – Light Touch

- Handwritten note.
- Simple:

“Just wanted you to know you matter to us.”

No heavy theology. Just belonging.

Month 3 – Personal Invitation

- Invite them to something specific (not generic Sunday).
    - Fellowship meal.
    - Men’s breakfast.
    - Small group.
    - Service project.

Specific invitations lower barriers.

Month 4 – Shepherd Awareness

If still absent:

- Quietly inform elders.
- Ask: “Is there something we’re missing?”
- Consider a joint visit (elder + deacon).

Not escalation. Shared care.

Month 5 – Practical Care Check

Ask:

- Any life changes?
- Health?
- Financial strain?
- Relational hurt?

Sometimes absence is embarrassment.

Month 6 – Honest Conversation

If they remain disengaged:

“We care about you, and we don’t want you walking alone. Is there something that has made church difficult?”

Clarity with kindness.

Important:

If at any point they clearly say:
“I don’t wish to attend anymore.”

Respond:

“Thank you for telling us. You’ll always be welcome.”

No argument.
Leave door open.

2️⃣ Once-a-Quarter Congregational Encouragement Strategy

This prevents drift before it starts.

A. Quarterly "We're In This Together" Reminder

Short pastoral moment (2–3 minutes in service):

- Church isn't an event.
- We are a body.
- If you disappear, we notice.
- If you're struggling, tell us.

Normalize struggle.

B. Quarterly Deacon Call Rotation

Each deacon calls 3–5 households per quarter:
Not because they missed.
Just to say:

“How can we pray for you?”

This builds relational capital before crisis.

C. Annual “Belonging Emphasis”

Once per year preach or teach on:

- Hebrews 10:24–25 (encouragement emphasis, not scolding)
- 1 Corinthians 12 (body life)
- Galatians 6:2 (burden bearing)

Frame it as joy, not obligation.

1️⃣ Flowchart: When Absence Becomes Discipline

Most absence is fatigue.
Some absence is drift.
A small portion becomes defiance.

You need clarity without suspicion.

🟢 Stage 1 — Ordinary Absence (0–4 Weeks)

Action:

- Gentle check-in call.
- Assume goodwill.
- Offer prayer.

Posture: Shepherding.

No elder involvement needed yet.

🟡 Stage 2 — Extended Absence (1–3 Months)

Action:

- Personal conversation.
- Ask direct but kind question:

“Is there something that’s making church difficult right now?”

- Notify elder overseeing the district.

Posture: Concerned clarity.

Still pastoral. Not corrective.

🟠 **Stage 3 — Patterned Withdrawal (3–6 Months)**

If:

- They avoid contact,
- Express disinterest,
- Or resist gathering intentionally.

Action:

- Elder + deacon visit.
- Clarify spiritual stakes gently.

“We care about you too much to let you drift quietly.”

Posture: Loving firmness.

Still invitational.

🔴 **Stage 4 — Formal Refusal If they say:**

- “I do not intend to return.”
- Or openly reject accountability.

Now elders must determine:

- Is this sin?
- Is this doctrinal rejection?
- Is this simply relocation?

Discipline is never about attendance alone. It is about:

- Persistent rebellion.
- Open abandonment of faith.
- Public scandal.

Always move slowly.
Always document.
Always pray.

2️⃣ Pastoral Conversation Guide for Hurt or Offended Members

This is common. Often silence hides hurt.

Step 1 — Lower Defenses

“I’m not here to correct you. I’m here to understand.”

Step 2 — Ask Open Question

“Was there something that made church hard recently?”

Let them talk.
Don’t interrupt.

Step 3 — Reflect Back

"So you felt overlooked when ___ happened."

People calm down when they feel heard.

Step 4 — Clarify Without Dismissing

If they say:

- "No one cares."

You respond:

"I'm sorry it felt that way. That was not our intent. Help me understand what would have helped."

Avoid:

- Defensiveness
- Quick theology
- "Well you should…"

Step 5 — Re-anchor in Body Life

“We aren’t perfect, but we belong to each other. Leaving quietly rarely heals the wound.”

Step 6 — Invite Re-engagement

Small steps:

- Sit near me Sunday.
- Coffee midweek.
- Join a small group.

Re-entry often needs a bridge.
